

EG Ukraine: Fedorov's ouster will cost Zelensky more than it solves

送信者: EG Europe 受信日時: 2026-07-17 02:19

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Ukraine

16 Jul 2026 13:18 EDT

Fedorov's ouster will cost Zelensky more than it solves

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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- * The dismissal of Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov as part of the government reshuffle on 15 July has turned into one of the most serious political confrontations of President Volodymyr Zelensky's tenure.
 - * The public and parliamentary backlash will erode Zelensky's domestic standing and deepen Western doubts about governance, just as allied assistance increasingly carries oversight conditions.
 - * The dismissal is a setback for defense reform, but Ukraine's drone-centered long-range strike strategy against Russia will continue.
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The government efficiency gains from the reshuffle will be overshadowed by the dismissal of the popular defense minister. Ukrainian media initially framed the change of government as a planned rotation tied to wartime and postwar reconstruction challenges. Fedorov's removal does not fit that framing, so much so that some political figures suggested in the press that the wider reshuffle served as cover for it.

Appointed six months ago, Fedorov built his standing on modernizing the military, and the public credited him with many of the army's successes. Part of Zelensky's logic was the conflict between Fedorov and the army. Generals resisted Fedorov's pace and style of military reform: push towards the use of KPIs, technology- and data-driven procurement. Fedorov said he sought to remove supreme commander General Oleksandr Syrsky, which Zelensky refused. MPs will likely cite the underperformance of his mobilization reform as the official justification. His dismissal, absent any serious performance concerns, is, however, hard to defend.

Beyond Fedorov, the cabinet changes fit the rotation narrative. The Verkhovna Rada, Ukraine's parliament, dismissed Prime Minister Yulia Svyrydenko's cabinet on 14 July and confirmed Serhiy Koretsky, the head of state energy company Naftogaz, as her successor on 16 July. Koretsky is a proven crisis manager tasked with hardening the energy system for another winter of Russian strikes. First

Deputy Prime Minister Denys Shmyhal and Finance Minister Serhiy Marchenko retain their posts, while the economy and infrastructure super-ministries will be split to sharpen delivery.

The political drivers behind the move will reflect poorly on Zelensky's decision-making. Three factors likely weighed in Zelensky's thinking. First, Fedorov's anti-corruption audit threatened established interests in an increasingly competitive arms-procurement market. Second, the Office of the President likely views him as a potential electoral rival, in part because he has kept his own political team intact. Finally, his popularity has grown with visible battlefield results. Notably, he declined an offer to become prime minister rather than abandon his defense reform mid-course-- underscoring that his removal was not his choice.

Domestically, the decision will weaken Zelensky regardless of how the situation resolves. The dismissal triggered the largest wartime protests since the July 2025 demonstrations over the National Anti-Corruption Bureau, and drew a protest resignation from Deputy Air Force Commander Col. Pavlo Yelizarov. It also provoked parliamentary resistance: the Rada sub-committee on state security and defense opposes the dismissal, and lawmakers criticized changing the defense minister every six months as depriving the ministry of strategy.

The backlash is forcing Zelensky to change his nominee from outgoing interior minister Ihor Klymenko to acting SBU chief Yevheny Khmara. This could ease concerns about the effect on military strategy, as Khmara has extensive experience in long-range strike operations against Russia. But he may not appease those focused on broader military restructuring, an issue where he has no track record. The Rada would have to approve him in a special session, as it concluded its regular spring session on 16 July without voting on the nomination.

The protests are likely to subside and Zelensky could yet find Fedorov another appointment. However, Zelensky's trust rating is likely to be hurt, as happened after Gen. Valery Zaluzhny's dismissal. There remains a chance that if the protests broaden into a movement about reform and transparency- as in 2025-- they will damage Zelensky's chances ahead of any postwar election.

Diplomatically, the move is unlikely to reduce material support but could heighten Western concerns about governance. European partners will continue to supply Ukraine with needed weapons. But if allies conclude Zelensky removed an effective reformer to protect political and procurement interests, it would compound concerns about the concentration of power in Kyiv and complicate assistance that increasingly embeds governance conditions. Western partners have insisted that Fedorov remain, viewing him as progressive, hands-on, and innovative. His departure leaves unclear who will oversee international cooperation, grants, and funding programs under a new ministry team, and many existing projects will face delays. The EU is already seeking assurances that joint weapons and drone-production programs will continue.

Militarily, the dismissal slows reform momentum but does not change the war strategy. The ultimate impact depends on whether Syrsky is also dismissed. Ukraine's drone-centered, asymmetric strategy predates Fedorov's appointment and is institutionalized across the armed forces and defense industry. Deep strikes against Russian energy and logistics will continue under any minister.

What will likely slow, amid resistance from Syrsky and the general staff, is the harder organizational reform: procurement transparency; broader military restructuring; and the recruitment overhaul. Replacing Syrsky with a like-minded commander would preserve that momentum; retaining him alongside a pliant minister would confirm the establishment has won this round.

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